Apocalyptic Butterflies

By Wendy MacLeod

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NOTE: Muriel is Hank's wife, Trudi is his mistress and Francine is his mother.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Cooped up in their cramped cottage in a remote part of Maine, Hank and Muriel Tater are beginning to get on each others' nerves*
ACTRESS: *They have still not agreed on a name for their seven-week-old daughter,*
ACTOR: *Muriel refuses to accept motherhood and housework as a full-time occupation.*
ACTRESS: *And Hank is having an affair with a busty checkout girl at the local IGA store.*
ACTOR: *In this series of scenes, we see Hank desperately trying to understand his position as a husband,*
ACTRESS: *But despite conversations with his wife, his mother and his mistress . . . Hank just doesn't seem to "get it"*
TOGETHER: *Apocalyptic Butterflies by Wendy MacLeod*

Hank is agitated, perhaps pacing when Muriel enters from outside with the baby and diaper bag.

HANK: **(Pg 26-29)** Where you been?

MURIEL: Where you been?

HANK: I asked you first

MURIEL: I stayed over your parents.

HANK: Why'd you stay over there? You got a house. What is this? I'm your husband. You're acting miserable. I get miserable just looking at you. Last time I seen you smile was [insert date]. You're like a pod person.

MURIEL: *(Looking around)* This place is a dump. How long you been sitting here? You never once thought to pick up.

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HANK: I thought about it, but I was too aggravated. I was wondering where you were. I thought you were with a man.

MURIEL: What man?

HANK: Any man. A man with a college education.

MURIEL: Let me ask you something. Where would I find a man with a college education in this town?

HANK: The ski resort

MURIEL: You thought I was with a skier with a college education.

HANK: It flashed before my eyes, yeah.

MURIEL: No one wants me, Hank. I'm not beautiful. I wear glasses.

HANK: You are. You are beautiful.

MURIEL: What the hell is this? In the sink, what's in the sink? *(Muriel hands the baby to Hank, grabs a sponge and furiously starts cleaning)*

HANK: Coffee grounds. I'll take care of it

MURIEL: How long have these grounds been in here? This will never come out

HANK: Just use a little of the green stuff on it, the ...

MURIEL: Comet! It's called Comet! Clean people use it to clean their houses! Men and women all over America use Comet to clean their houses!

HANK: Who's acting crazy now Muriel?

MURIEL: How many times have I told you I need some help running this house, I am not your maid! I am a Magna Cum Laude graduate of the University of Maine Augusta. I change this baby twelve times a day, when she sleeps I stay awake with my ear tuned to a baby intercom. When she's hungry I get up and I feed her, when you're hungry I feed you and in between everybody's hunger I clean and I clean and I clean and this house still looks dark and dirty! *(Muriel starts to get the baby's things together)*

HANK: Where ya going?

MURIEL: Howard Johnson's motel where somebody else cleans the room! *(Muriel exits with the baby and the diaper bag)*

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********* Hank's mother's trailer ********

HANK: **(Pg 29-31)** She took the baby and went to the Howard Johnson's. I didn't get to the cleaning like I promised so bam she's out the door, screaming about coffee grounds. I don't know what to do, Ma, I don't know what to do.

FRANCINE: Why don't you clean the house like you promised?

HANK: Right Exactly. Take her side. See it through her eyes. She's dropping a bundle at the Hojos, putting it on ***my*** plastic and she's the victim. I work 40 hours a week, what the hell does she do?

FRANCINE: She works 80 hours a week, bubba.

HANK: Bubba?

FRANCINE: You used to be more than some bubba. Then you started acting like the rest of this town with the pick-up and the language and the girls.

HANK: What girls?

FRANCINE: The girl at the IGA. What's her name? The girl with the *chest (Hank shrugs, indicating no knowledge)* You better know her name! If you slept with some girl and you don't even know her name . . .

HANK: Trudi.

FRANCINE: Get rid of the girl, Hank. If Muriel doesn't know for sure she senses. You don't need a girl, you need a wife.

HANK: She hasn't been a wife to me. She hasn't been a wife to me for a long, long time. Muriel she don't love me no more. I try to touch her, she turns away.

FRANCINE: Maybe she's tired from the baby.

HANK: My house has a disgusting smell. There's the crying and the diapers and the smell of milk boiling. Trudi she wears this body lotion, this perfume lotion. Ciara. Like the wind.

FRANCINE: There's nothing wrong with the way your house smells, Hank. Your house smells like life. When are you gonna name that baby? A baby needs a name, Hank. There's something not right about a baby with no name. . . . **(Pg 32-34)** Do the right thing. Call up the girl, Hank, tell her it's over. *(Pause)*

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HANK: I can't break up with her on the phone.

FRANCINE: Well, you can't go see her.

HANK: I can't go to her house, she can't come to my house, I can't call her, what am I supposed to do?

FRANCINE: Write her a letter.

HANK: Okay but you gotta assist me 'cause I don't know how not to hurt a woman's feelings. *(Hank gets a pad and pencil)* Dear Trudi, You are a very nice girl. The nicest. The sweetest girl I met in a long time.

FRANCINE: Hank. You're breaking up with her.

HANK: Dear Trudi, My mother says I should make up with Muriel and name my baby. Neither of these things involve you so good-bye. Hank. *(Pause)* It's no good. I can't break up with her in a letter, I got to see her in person -- prove to myself I can resist her temptations.

FRANCINE: The best way to resist temptation is to avoid temptation.

HANK: Ma, this is what's gonna happen. I'm gonna go home. Muriel' s gonna remain elsewhere. I'm gonna call Trudi, tell her come over I gotta talk with her, then I'm gonna tell her me and her we're a memory. . . I'm gonna kiss her softly and sweetly . . . .

FRANCINE: Watch that softly and sweetly stuff!

HANK: . . . on the forehead! Right Ma. I gotta go!

FRANCINE: *(Calling after him)* What if Muriel comes home?

HANK: She won't. I know that woman like I know discount shoes!

*********Hank and Muriel's Home ********

TRUDI: **(Pg 35)** You sure it's okay? I got beat up one time by a wife. Where's Muriel?

HANK: **(Pg 36-37)** She's at the Howard Johnson's. She's temporarily left me.

TRUDI: She find out about me?

HANK: It was something else. It pertained to coffee grounds.

HANK: Trudi, I can't come around no more. I'm breaking up with you.

TRUDI: Okay.

HANK: Okay. That's it? You're not rejected and sad and crumpled?

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TRUDI: No.

HANK: You didn't love me?

TRUDI: Probably not.

HANK: But you said you did. You said I love you, I love you. Didn't you ever think what if I left Muriel and married you?

TRUDI: No. I mean, who wants to marry a guy cheats on his wife? Muriel's in it for the long haul. I just use married men as a resource. You thought about getting married to me?

HANK: Yeah. I'm one person with you. I'm another person here.

TRUDI: **(Pg 38-39)** You're the same person. I want to kiss this person good- bye.

(Trudi and Hank kiss. Muriel enters carrying the baby. She sees them, registers it and walks back out. Beat. Trudi and Hank look at each other. Muriel re-enters.

MURIEL: You, tits, get out of my house!

(Trudi exits. Hank furiously begins to scrub the sink. He tapers off and looks at Muriel.)

HANK: I was breaking it off with her.

MURIEL: You obviously weren't being real firm about that!

HANK: She wanted to kiss me good-bye.

MURIEL: Kiss me good-bye baby, 'cause I'm outta here. You insult me. You insult everything I am by choosing my opposite.

HANK: You looked at me like I wasn't here, like in your head you'd already left me. The baby cries when I try to hold her, and when I try to hold you, you move away *(Muriel heads for the door)* IT'S SNOWING OUT THERE! You'll skid, you'll die, I'll never see you again. I'll never see the baby again. I'll be in a dark suit following two coffins to the grave, ladies in veils will hand me tissues.

MURIEL: Okay. I'll stay. You get out I'm the injured party, you get out.

HANK: Muriel, I am a man with primordial urges. . .

MURIEL: You could do with a few less primordial urges, buddy.

HANK: Yeah right Muriel, stick the knife in and twist it. I bring you my shame. I have deposited my shame at your feet and still you torment me.

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MURIEL: Your shame. You've deposited your shame at my feet?

HANK: Yeah.

MURIEL: BIG DEAL! I don't want your shame. I can't use your shame. I can't frame your shame and put it up on my wall. I can't cook your shame and eat it for breakfast. I can't bottle your shame and dab it behind my ears. Your shame means nothing to me!

HANK: **(Pg 12)** JESUS CHRIST MURIEL!

MURIEL: What?

HANK: Be nice to me. Be sweet to me. I need . . . some sweetness in my life.

MURIEL: **(Pg 42)** Save your breath, Hank. Things were bad long before I walked in this house tonight. There is nothing there is nada there is zero you could possibly say to me to make me reconcile with you! *(the baby gurgles)*

HANK: **(Pg 45)** She's giggling at me this baby. *(Hank takes the baby, focuses on her instead of Muriel)* Who's giggling me? Who's giggling me? *(to Muriel)* Muriel. A name flashed before my eyes. Not **(pg 13)** Lorelei or Jessica or Velvet or Elvira *(pause)* **(Pg 45)** A hybrid name like two flowers joined together. Your name and my name. Together.

MURIEL: Murank?

HANK: No, my real name. Henry. Henriel.

MURIEL: Henriel?

TOGETHER: *(softly)* Henriel.

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AWARD HISTORY

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